Teaching Statement

Filipa Calado

This teaching statement covers my teaching philosophy, the courses I've taught at Pratt, curriculum development, mentoring and advising, and future plans.

Philosophy

As a language scholar who uses digital tools, I have experience teaching in two general areas: English and computer science. In the area of English, I have taught courses on academic writing, critical thinking, and Latinx literature. On the side of computer science, I have taught courses Python programming, natural language processing, data science, and machine learning.

From this background, I have developed a teaching philosophy that blends together humanist and computational skills, taking a humanist approach to computational tools and objects. This philosophy is organized into three core principles:

1. the close is critical;
2. writing as an active learning method; and
3. knowledge is always contingent

In what follows, I explain these core principles in more detail.

1) the close is critical:

In my courses, regardless of their format or focus, I teach close reading as an essential critical practice. Originating from literary studies, close reading is a particular kind of qualitative analysis that sustains attention on a very small selection of evidence, traditionally, a passage in a text. I find that close reading helps students not only to analyze evidence, like textual passages, depth, but also to generate new ways of using and interpreting all kinds of data.

For example, in my INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage course, I have students consider large datasets on an intimate scale, demonstrating how attention to detail can reveal new material for analysis and critique. In my INFO 664 class from last fall, I had several students develop projects which used Small Language Models (SLMs) to examine gender bias in popular culture,[1] to study discourses of toxic online spaces,[2] and to surface patterns in sensationalist language[3]—three projects which ended up winning the 2026 Info Show's "People's Choice Award."

[1] Jace Steiner, "Considering Transformers Models as a Tool for Character Analysis with Finn the Human." Fall 2025. `https://xxsteinxx.github.io/chara-analysis_at/`.

[2] Ellen Connors. "Machine Divinity." Fall 2025. `https://econn170.github.io/machine-divinity/index.html`.

[3] Alana Maisel. "The New York Post's Environment and Wildlife." Fall 2025. `https://amaisel1.github.io/nypost-environment-and-wildlife/aboutproject.html`.

2) writing as an active learning method:

I am a strong proponent of writing as a powerful and irreplaceable skill for professional work. All of my courses emphasize the development of this skill—all the more forcefully when emerging AI technologies threaten to reduce students' intellectual capacities to the capacityof any given tool.

Writing is, in my experience, the most efficient method of active learning: it requires externalizing one's inner understanding in a coherent and material way, while also exposing it to alternative perspectives and real-world issues. In my courses, I teach writing both through low stakes, daily formats like freewriting exercises, and in long term assignments like formal papers. For example, in my INFO 656: Machine Learning course, the major assignment is a conference paper that students complete in groups and submit to a machine learning (ML) conference. This assignment not only keeps them up to date with recent advances in a rapidly changing field, it also encourages students to think deeply about their contributions to ML research within a professionalizing context.

3) knowledge is always contingent:

One of the first lessons I learned in the classroom is the importance meeting students where they are, regardless of their previous training. One way of doing so is to invite students to use their lived experience as a ground for understanding and critique—to assure them that their own histories, combined with reflection, constitute a valuable kind of knowledge. A necessary corollary to knowledge as experience is to accept that there can be no single perspective for any question or issue. Rather than a single perspective, there are degrees of visibility made available through habit and privilege.

In my teaching, I try to expand what is visible through the exposure to a wide range of theoretical points of view, particularly in the interdisciplinary selection of readings from my courses like INFO 601, INFO 656, and INFO 657. Readings in these courses explore fields such as Black Feminist Studies, Archival Studies, and AI Ethics research, which address similar topics through different initial questions, assumptions, approaches, and conclusions.

Courses

I have taught the following courses since beginning my position at Pratt in Fall 2024. Included for each course is information about the semesters taught and number of students served, links to course materials like syllabi and github repositories, and excerpts from teaching evaluations.

- INFO 656: Machine Learning
  - Semesters taught: Fall 2026
  - Students served: 11
  - Course github: `https://github.com/gofilipa/656`
  - Course syllabus: `https://github.com/gofilipa/656/blob/main/syllabus.pdf`

- INFO 657: Digital Humanities
  - Semesters taught: Spring 2026
  - Students served: 11
  - Couse syllabus: `https://bit.ly/657-spring2026`
  - Excerpts from course evaluations::
    * *Professor Calado's welcoming approach to our discussions helped to foster a mutually supportive classroom environment in which we were all genuinely interested in each other's work, and cheering each other on […] I loved the range of readings and the chance to get introduced to so many DH tools.*
    * *I loved the subject matter & topics Dr. Calado choose throughout the course, it really sparked my interest in DH and helped me understand theoretical approaches to DH […] I'm really happy she brough in guest-speakers from the field, doing this also helped me understand how I could possibly incorporate DH into my career path and gave me more options to exlpore.[sic]*
- INFO 697: Special Topics - How to Build a Bot
  - Semesters taught: Summer 2025
  - Students served: 6
  - Course github: `https://github.com/gofilipa/botz`
  - Course syllabus: `https://github.com/gofilipa/botz/blob/main/syllabus.pdf`
  - Excerpts from course evaluations:
    * *I feel that now I have a superpower, and I'm eager to keep practicing!*
    * *Filipa is a great instructor and I've really enjoyed this class, each week was super interesting and I really appreciate her perspectives on coding, automation, and pretty much everything*
    * *The conjunction of critical thinking supported by readings with technical learning.*
- INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage
  - Semesters taught: Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026
  - Students served: 55
  - Course syllabus: `https://bit.ly/664-fall26`
  - Python notebooks: `https://gofilipa.github.io/664`
  - Student projects: `https://gofilipa.github.io/664-projects`
  - Excerpts from course evaluations:

    * *I would make this a required course for all LIS students. I wish I would have taken this course sooner, of all classes this one has impacted my learning outcomes most.*
    * *[T]his is the first teacher I had that has effectively taught me how to code. She makes complex topics easy to understand no matter what experience or background a student may or may not have with coding.*
    * *This course is really fun. Even if you aren't trying to be a programmer, you learn really useful skills and it helps you understand the internet and data on a deeper level.*

- INFO 601: Foundations of Information
  - Semesters taught: Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026
  - Students served: 103
  - Course syllabus: `https://bit.ly/601-fall26`
  - Excerpts from course evaluations:
    * *The writing workshops we had in class for our research papers were very helpful. I also think the professor's breakdown of essay writing was the most coherent I have ever heard. I have never had a college course that bothered to go over the mechanics of writing a large paper before, despite studying English in my undergrad. The tools I have gathered from the writing workshops and essay writings will be invaluable for me moving forward.*
    * *She made the environment of the classroom so welcoming and safe, which I think encouraged a lot of people to be able to speak up. She would work really hard to be inclusive, ask questions to make us consider other POVs and also took feedback from us to adjust assignments or due dates based on our needs.*

Curriculum Development

In Summer 2025, I taught a new course, INFO 697: How to Build a Bot, which combines hands-on programming with critical examination of coding, automation, and the social implications of bots. I plan to continue developing the curriculum through additional courses in intermediate-level programming. As I explain in more detail in the Future Plans section below, I plan to develop a Python course focused specifically on working with text-based data, building on a workshop I currently offer through the Data Storytelling Lab.

Throughout the past academic year, I have also worked on revising the DH Certificate to bring it up to date with the most recent theories and tools in DH. In collaboration with my colleague, John Decker, we re-organized the DH Certificate into two knowledge areas or "buckets," (1) Theories and Methods and (2) Technologies, to reflect changing trends in DH scholarship as well as to better professionalize students for careers in DH and related work.

Mentoring & Advising

In addition to the 30 or so students that I teach directly each semester, I currently advise 35 students across all four programs at Pratt SI. Each semester, I meet individually with these students to discuss their progress in coursework and projects, to strategize their final portfolios, and career expectations and goals.

I also advise two students groups: the *Stacks* Student Journal and Latines in Tech. The *Stacks* Student Journal is a new group founded by students from my INFO 601: Foundations of Information course. These students are in the process of producing their first issue of the *Stacks* journal, which will contain peer-reviewed versions of their 601 papers, showcasing the high level of critical work and writing accomplished in that course. The second group, Latines in Tech, is professional development group primarily focused on Latinx students. Their main goals are to provide professional development and networking opportunities for their members. Currently, I am working with that group to organize a community altar for to celebrate Dia de los Muertos at the end of October.

Future Plans

My future plans involve developing the following:

- In collaboration with my colleague Kathy Carbone, I plan to develop a study abroad program based in Lisbon, Portugal. The program will likely focus on an intersection of DH and archival work, though we are still in the early stages of discussing the possibilities.
- I also plan to develop a "Readings in Queer Studies" seminar style course. While I am aware that theoretically heavy courses have been less popular at Pratt SI, I think students' appetite for theoretical material is growing. In courses like INFO 601: Foundations of Information and INFO 657: Digital Humanities, the assigned readings in queer studies generate much interest and discussion, especially among students in LIS, who often claim them as their favorite readings. For this course, I would complement the seminar focus with fieldwork activity that involves visiting queer archives in New York City.
- Finally, I plan to develop a Python programming course that is specific to working with text-based data. This course would build from my workshop that I run for the Data Storytelling Lab, which focuses on using advanced tools for text cleaning, processing, annotating, and NLP analysis. This course would join my other course, INFO 697: How to Build a Bot, to offer instruction in intermediate programming skills.